



**Universitat de les
Illes Balears**

Facultat de Filosofia i Lletres

Memòria del Treball de Fi de Grau

Negotiating Power: Revision, Subversion and Bhabha's Mimicry Dynamics in Tarantino's *Django Unchained* (2012) and the Black American Dream

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Any acadèmic 2023-24

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Abstract

Slavery and its violent rhetoric are frequently presented on the screen as prominent witnesses of a grim U.S. period. This research paper addresses a critical reading on how *Django Unchained* (2012), an outstanding contemporary Western film, uses subversion to encourage the Black American dream, or dissimilarly, as a tool for reinforcing racial inequalities. This paper examines film's power dynamics and apparatuses in perpetrating slavery's outrageous discourse and the hegemonic notion of "race". This project of rethinking history applies various scholarly perspectives to scrutinize how subversion of the revisionist Western, the cowboy's role stratagem, and the authoritarian dynamics through mimicry constitute a pivotal step toward the black American dream. For this, a profound analysis of Django will be executed, not only presenting him as a revengeful character but also as a resilient and recognised individual. *Django Unchained* tallies a fictional narrative offering an alternative view of a rebellious slave, while not sacrificing altogether the historical portrait of the Antebellum period.

Keywords: subversion, power, slavery, mimicry, the American dream.

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Introduction

Released in 2012, *Django Unchained* was written and directed by the well-known Quentin Tarantino. This Hollywood's contemporary Western is contextualized in the Antebellum period of the United States, particularly in 1858, and it yields an atypical perspective by placing the Black eponymous character as the outstanding cowboy. The film's *discourse* examination: "a system of subjection in which...state apparatus[es]...use, select or impose certain of its methods" (Foucault 1977, 26) is crucial for applying this analysis to 1861 slavery's colonial remnant; "an apparatus of power...that turns on the recognition and disavowal of racial...differences" (Bhabha 1984, 100). Thus, it examines the racial perpetuation power discourses disseminated by portraying the horrors and inequality African Americans suffered. The film embodies a revisionist Western, given its overturning effect of the traditional Western platitudes and its deviation from the original *Django* (1966) (Bieger, 2017). In light of this, the presentation of the characters and topics is crucial for the subsequent paper.

This slave narrative about revenge and pursuit for freedom presents the junctures of Django, a slave freed by Dr King Schultz, a White German bounty hunter masked under a dentist, who requires him to identify three wanted men, the Brittle brothers. Django accepted seeking revenge for his previous masters' punishments on him and Broomhilda, his wife, underscoring slavery's devastating repercussions. After capturing them at Bennett's plantation, Django, delighted to hunt Whites, becomes Schultz's apprentice. In exchange, Schultz agrees to embark on an expedition to free Broohmhilda, who was in Candyland, a Mississippi plantation. They pretend to be purchasers of Mandingo fighters to rescue her, albeit their plot is ruined by Candie's loyal servant Stephen, who suspecting the duo's intentions informs the master and creates a brawl. The film concludes with a massacre, resulting in Candie and Schultz's death coupled with Django's purchase by LeQuint Dickey. However, Django manages to escape, returns to Candyland, kills the opposers, and frees his wife.

Scholars like Bhabha and Said have provided postcolonial theories considering the historical disparities when asserting dominion over the contemplated "inferior" races, focusing on notions such as mimicry, ambivalence, and defining "otherness". Likewise, academics such as Foucault, Althusser and Trouillot endowed foundational insights into the intricate dynamics between power exertion and apparatuses disseminating inequalities. Nonetheless, the full spectrum of implications the hegemonic mechanisms entail, not only as oppressive hallmarks

but also as subverting artefacts presenting Django as a revisionist cowboy, have not been thoroughly discussed.

During the history of cinema, directors like Sidney Poitier with *Buck and the Preacher* (1972), Mel Brooks with *Blazing Saddles* (1974), and Van Peebles with *Posse* (1993) have provided resilience stories on the screen, changing the role of the Black character (Maguire, 2014) and allowing him to transcend the boundaries of stereotypes. Moreover, they enable to redefine identities while revising and decoding injustices historically extended through colonialism and imperialism. Additionally, *Django Unchained* (2012) presents an example of how “race” is nothing more than a social construction. Framed in Postcolonial and New Ethnic Studies, this paper considers “race” in the film as an attempted elucidation on how it only favours the assumed “superior”, which is examined through the Critical Race Theory.

My research question concerns how power discourse is represented in the film, in what ways it intervenes in Django’s journey and whether his subversion fosters the Black American dream, contributing along with this revisionist Western to “unchaining”. This paper addresses these questions by revising power apparatuses and their subversion as enhancing engines. It aims to synthesize various scholarly perspectives on power structures, racial discourse and traumatic scars illustrated in the film. It focuses on Bhabha’s mimicry, defined as the determination colonizers had to become models for the “Others”, who according to Said (1979) denote strangeness, perceiving “the signifier of ‘skin/race’” (Bhabha 1984, 113) as a discriminator. Mimicry implies imitating the dominant patterns, which can be used as a resistance weapon when sabotaging the assumed White superiority by mocking, thus, ridiculizing them while asserting agency. This analysis ponders how Django’s interactions with other characters benefit him, setting an example for African Americans while involving a comparative literature review to dissect key findings elucidating subversion's myriad.

This paper conducts its film analysis in four sections; the first revises slavery as a trigger of the hegemonic power and considers the potential of the revisionist Western in shaping Django. The second part reviews the conventional cowboy’s role while evaluating its subversive impact, and examines the complex Dr Schultz. The next section introduces the concept of mimicry by comparing and polarizing Django and Stephen. Finally, the paper provides the results achieved considering Django’s role in fostering the Black American dream.

1 Revising

1.1 Slavery and Discourse

Slavery, defined as “granting...one man exercises and enforces a right of property in the body and soul of another” (Douglass 2003, 139) displayed an impactful role in U.S. history. Slavery was a remnant of colonialism—which supposed the transportation of millions of African slaves to form the colonies (Trouillot, 1995)—and a coetaneous extension of imperialistic ideologies. This institution evolved into an anchored framework of subjugation where this “colonial system [vestige] strengthen[s] and uphold[s]” (Fanon 1968, 238) its financial gain and hierarchy through stereotypes (Douglass, 2003), state apparatuses, and supremacist assumptions. Literary productions of this dreadful institution abound, ranging from firsthand reports of Equiano or Beecher Stowe to contemporary productions of Morrison or Whitehead. Particularly, I consider Friedrich Douglass (2003) and Delgado and Stefancic (2012), who highlight this institution’s inherent violent discourse and its detestable procedures that interplay with outrageous invasions of rights.

Slavery contributed to a larger picture of domination provoking discriminating and ruthless practices that reinforced: “histories of the excluded” (Bhabha 1984, 8) erasement. Whites exert “a collection of patterns and habits [as]...domination” (Delgado & Stefancic 2012, 5) over the inferiorly perceived Blacks. This discourse highlights Said’s (1979) concept of “Otherness” in that ethnic difference is used for perpetuating inequality and racial segregation. Trouillot (1995) addresses history as a power execution of the winners’ will, extending the dominant version over the invalidated and silenced narrative. Thus, as Said’s (1979, 13) contention reveals “history is made...with various silences and elisions”, undoubtedly, a controlling device. These dynamics were supported by the assumption that those “rational, virtuous, mature, ‘normal’” (69) had the duty to civilize the degenerated (Fanon, 1968) Other, portrayed as “passive,...non-autonomous, non-sovereign” (Said 1979, 134). Undeniably, this process of racializing “evidence[s]...the prevalence...of white ascendancy and superior” (Nelson 2010, 29) beliefs when undermining a minority.

Slavery may be understood in Foucauldian terms as a *discipline*: “a specific technique of power that regards individuals both as objects and as instruments of its exercise” (Foucault 1997, 170). Foucault presents that humans can be deprived of their rights and freedom when enslaving them, using their bodies as enclosures. Consequently, punishment is “an instrument and vector of power” (30) for moulding people into submissive pawns without questioning

power dynamics. The critic coins this controlling interest as “disciplinary power” which demands to exploit and control “the body and its forces, their utility and their docility, their distribution and their submission” (25).

Similarly, this framework of supremacy and subjugation might be considered through Althusser’s (2014, 368) Ideological State Apparatus: “a force of repressive execution and intervention in the interests of the ruling classes”. ISAs are crucial for implementing, disseminating and evaluating the dominant paradigm when shaping the submissive discourse. In the film, power dynamics are reinforced by ISAs such as plantation owners and overseers, using violence and coercion against the considered “inferior”. Carrucan’s, Bennett’s and Candyland are spaces “constituted socially...[and] the site of a ‘realization’ of ideology” (34). Likewise, plantations in the film allow a historical and economic outlook where individuals were subjected to predominant ideologies. They offer a glimpse into the physical and psychological conditions African Americans suffered, being sold and purchased as commodities to work.

Such are the uncountable examples of torture and segregation Tarantino used to emphasise slavery’s atrocity that navigating some of the most remarkable scenes is crucial when revising its effects. The notion of chaining as a deprivation of freedom, contrary to the film’s title, foreshadows the subduing nature of White supremacists. The usage of retention instruments, namely, ropes, shackles, and whips demonstrates the “perverse brutality that stems from the ruling class’s intermingling practices of punishment and leisure” (Bieger 2017, 144). Undeniably, the film accounts for a shivery description of lynching, lacerations, and humiliation. The runaway “r” mark on Django and Broomhilda’s cheek and their whip marks evidence this torture.

The Mandingo fight (Tarantino 2012, 01:03:46-01:06:57), where two slaves used as bets are forced to fight until death, the dog attack ordered by Candie in which a dog shreds an attempted fugitive slave (01:23:40-01:24:10), and the hot box used as a punishment measure for Broomhilda (01:33:52-01:34:06) are among others the most impactful scenes portraying the insensitivity of slavery. Additionally, the proleptic KKK intervention (00:41:08-00:44:43), a Postbellum supremacist group that instigated fear and racism, poses a counterbalance using “satirical humour as a way to make the horrors of slavery more palatable and acceptable” (Johnson 2014, 212). Verdi’s “Dies Irae” appliance in the rider’s entrance pursuing Django and Schultz denotes tension. Contrastingly, their debate “of not being able to see through their hoods yet decide to wear them nonetheless out of respect to the work that one of their wives has put

into them” (Bieger 2017, 145), altogether state comicality that releases the content, ultimately ridiculizing them.

Slavery ended after the Civil War (1865), notwithstanding, Trouillot (1995, 17) claims that “past is evoked as the starting point of an ongoing traumatism and as a necessary explanation to current inequalities suffered by blacks”. This interpretation further underscores the origins of U.S. discrimination and disparities, remnants of prior beliefs and practices. Therefore, under no circumstance should individuals fail to consider slavery as part of U.S. history since “American people [were] responsible for slavery, and must...not cover up...national sins, but to inspire...sincere repentance” (Douglass 2003, 336-338). Hence, “its historical past and its narrative present” (Bhabha 1984, 22) harms must be considered to understand “racism...[as] a modern phenomenon” (Trouillot 1995, 19). Correspondingly, all prejudices and deprivations promulgated were to uphold control under the despised pretext of “race”. Nonetheless, “Race is not real or objective, but constructed, racism and prejudice should be capable of deconstruction” (Delgado and Stefancic 2012, 49), foreshadowing this revolutionary Western power.

1.2 The Western Genre

On a different note, assessing the current state of affairs is imperative to comprehend this revisionist Western’s potential. “The word ‘revisionist’ signals a reexamination or correction of something that already exists” (Nelson 2010, 19). Originally, “Western ideological baggage includes racism and imperialis[tic]” (26) determination for West expansion, portraying conflicts between Native Americans and Whites. This cinematic genre needed rescripting since “white audiences believed Western films represented an accurate portrayal of the American West.” (Maguire 2014, 4). Consequently, some scholars and filmmakers have been challenging this traditional narrative seeking to overhaul this genre, evolving to address “inclusivity and multiculturalism” (Nelson 2010, 26). If it is true that slavery ceased, White supremacist ideologies disseminating racism are still oppressing Blacks. Precisely, this film’s release (2012) coincided with Obama’s election, recalling the “journey that African Americans have made and continue to make in a nation that still presents racial obstacles” (Maguire 2014, 4). Tarantino’s production adapts Western motifs to reflect on both the past, using Django’s violence to denounce slavery and the racist discourse, and the present pervasive U.S. disturbances (Aquila, 2015).

This revisionist Western fosters Black freedom through Django. This can be considered through the lens of the Critical Race Theory; a “movement...interested in studying and

transforming the relationship among race, racism, and power.” (Delgado and Stefancic 2012, 3). Both scholars suggest that CRT provides a resilient grasp concerning nationalism and collective empowerment while reconsidering historical improprieties. Without a doubt, *Django Unchained* (2012) represents a 21st-century fictional and alternative rewriting of U.S. history. Moreover, the Western style promotes a chance to confront racism and denounce as Johnson (2014) alleges the dominant narrative by revising the atrocities slaves experienced. Choosing a slave as the hero seeking revenge on slaveholders (Johnson, 2014) allows voicing a historically muted ethnicity, demonstrating that “something has to be done to fix society” (Angott 2016, 16). I contend that Tarantino holds the genre’s essence, reflecting on the past while exhibiting a multicultural outlook showcasing a lesson through revenge; every African American configures the U.S. and should be considered.

All in all, this film’s historical revision allows the spectator to understand its violent background while acknowledging the notion of power discourse in shaping History and cinema. Above all, *Django Unchained* (2012) stands as a revisionist Western by reexamining conventions. Namely, changing the subject to a Black American hero allows a first step toward the Black American dream, particularly when appraising the cowboy’s role.

2. Subverting the Cowboy: the Black Hero and His Key for Freedom

2.1 Reverting the White Cowboy’s Predominant Apparition

This Western offers a Black cowboy protagonist, which is imperative for its rescript since this role was originally shaped through the hegemonic view. Isherwood (2015) argues that this genre was based on the White discourse in which the "Other" was presented as a challenge for civilization's sake to whom White heroes must surmount; thus, the Other existed as an antithesis to the White brave cowboy. Their narratives emerged from supremacist ideologies intended to maintain the status quo and disseminate racism. According to Trouillot (1995), films were citizens' primary sources of learning about colonial America, leading to a historically distorted viewpoint. Undoubtedly, these cinematic apparatuses misrepresented Blacks portrayed as “degenerate, uncivilized and retarded” (Said 1979, 255), hence, further instilling differences by maintaining the authoritative patterns. Certainly, the impactful presentation of stereotypes on speech, behaviours, and characterization roles denotes inferiority. Nonetheless, this film’s cowboy role has been revised and subverted offering a reconsideration of the usually silenced

perspective. This shift allows one to re-read it as a “vehicle to re-imagine history from a black perspective and challenges the myth of white-supremacy” (Isherwood 2015, 53).

2.2 The Black Hero

Django allows “rewriting and reimagining African Americans' role in American history” (Maguire 2014, 13) being a Black cowboy. Only by providing a new approach that sacrifices historical accuracy could Tarantino propose this complex story of resilience and empowerment. Django Freeman is presented as a Black avenger by altering the hegemonic ideology and embodying “the hero that America wishes could have existed” (Vogel 2018, 17), or contrarily being perceived as an antihero for retaliating. Althusser (2014, 342) determines that “if the function of the ISAs is to inculcate the dominant ideology, the reason is that there is resistance”. Freeman offers opposition embodying a rebellious character who despite his misfortunes will rebound resilient.

Such imperative is Django’s role that Tarantino (8FLiX 2012, 1) introduces him as “One of the seven slaves is our hero DJANGO”. In his toil of retaliator he might be read as a hero since he struggles against the evilness of slavery and who allows it; pursuing his “individual act of vengeance [while]...involv[ing] the slave community” (Baud 2013, 9). His ambition to rescue Broomhilda, and not only to retaliate against slavery’s havoc but also to seek justice against the system's segregative impositions and limitations stimulates him by subverting the established racial schemes. Ultimately, this revisionist Western poses Django as a subverting character contributing to “unchaining” from previous traditions and assumptions while fostering the Black American dream in standing as a protective, representative and influential symbol for historically affected Blacks.

2.3 Dr King Schultz, the Mentor’s Role. Abolitionist or Perpetrator?

2.3.1 Abolitionist Perspective

Alternatively, Dr. King Schultz is who allows Django to unchain from slavery. He represents Django’s mentor, for whom Freeman manages his development. Thanks to the doctor’s instruction Django learnt the bounty hunter’s profession, allowing him to become “the fastest gun of the south” (8FLiX 2012, 176). Schultz offers him an alternative to a condemned life which leads Django to embody the pinnacle of revenge when persecuting slavery operators. Hence, Schultz assists his upraising and supports abolitionism “a movement to end the institution of slavery” (Baud 2013, 17). Undoubtedly, Schultz represents a complex character,

offering a progressive and liberal view that aligns with Angott's (2016) interpretation that while professing to be more focused on business than ethnicity, he opposes slavery seeming to appropriate the dominant narrative, albeit not subscribing to it. Essentially, he exploits his acting values and persuasive skills to benefit from moral corruption, which is perceivable in the opening when he tries to purchase Django so the Spek do not suspect.

Schultz may be read as an abolitionist character in allowing Django to unchain from society's constrictions, encouraging his insurrection in a White hegemonic society while validating and defending him. He shelters Django when meeting characters such as the Spek and Marshall Tatum in Texas. Furthermore, he intercedes for Django when several White characters such as Bennett or Candie's crew try to oppress him. Moreover, he cares for Django's fate: "I feel vaguely responsible for you." (8FLiX 2012, 43), "I can't let you go to Greenville in a good conscious." (42) further portraying the danger pro-slavers Southern states presented. After this conversation, they negotiate to continue together as bounty hunters while looking for Broomhilda, which empowers Django since "No white man has ever done anything for Django" (43).

Not only is Schultz acting against slavery when rescuing Django, but he also demonstrates empathy for those enslaved, trying to protect some by lashing out their owners (Baud, 2003). One of these scenes is when he denounces Candie's aberrations. He criticises Candie's dog order attack (Tarantino 2012, 01:23:40) on D'Artagnan (a slave) by challenging Candie's admiration for Dumas, stating "What Dumas would make of all this?" (8FLiX 2012, 139), since he was Black. This demonstrates Schultz's erudition and his determination against the dehumanizing institution.

Everything considered, Schultz is crucial for Django's development, establishing a learning model to enhance empowerment and resistance, which Django uses to call for the Black American dream recognition. Contrarily, although Schultz is presented as an abolitionist, he could alternatively be understood as an oppressor. The complexity of Schultz lies in considering the other side of the coin; how he uses the hegemonic discourse to his benefit.

2.3.2 System's Perpetrator

Schultz profits from slavery, albeit in his seemingly abolitionist view. His actions are guided by supremacist assumptions, strengthening unequal system dynamics. His operations are partially driven by "The White Man's Burden" ideology (Vogel 2018, 20), which according to Kipling (1954) constitutes the duty Whites had to conquer and civilize the non-White. Trouillot (1995, 7) claims that Blacks were "associate[d] with savagery..., proof of...inferiority" in

opposition to the portrayal of Whites, “those [who] guard” (Kipling 1954, 321), presented as paternalistic heroes. Schultz is seen as a saviour with the duty of freeing Django insofar as his interests were concerned. Vogel (2018, 26) states that this “saving” operation demonstrates that the film “cannot be separated from a long history of racially inflected tropes that represent white men as...the heroes, the saviors”.

Despite Schultz stating that he despises slavery, he needs Django’s help arguing: “if you’re not in a position to refuse, all the better. So for the time being, I’m going to make this slave malarkey work to my benefit” (8FLiX 2012, 13). Hence, he fosters inequality using his position as White to pursue his motivations, using Django to identify the Brittle. Nevertheless, Schultz conveniently inverts the situation with the pretext of helping Django to assert freedom and revenge, thus, portraying a confluence of inclinations. This mirrors Bell’s (1980) principle of interest-convergence in that only when Black racial advancements support White self-interest will controllers endorse them.

It could be argued that Schultz is perceived as the White paternal saviour embodying Kipling’s ideology of “conquering” the helpless Django as a moral and noble cause. Notwithstanding, this heroism does not match an altruist view since he does it for his own interest and dictates the dynamics: “Django is only free insofar as he follows Schultz’s instructions” (Vogel 2018, 26). He frees Django, yet appeals to slavery to threaten him if he refuses his petition, thus, Django had no other alternative than to accept voluntarily or forcefully. This aligns with Said’s (1979, 277) outlook on Kipling’s poem alleging: “behind the White Man’s mask of amiable leadership there is always the express willingness to use force”.

Their dependence is undeniable, albeit “Schultz sets the terms..., [he] is always superior”(Vogel 2018, 25). This relation could mirror Hegel’s (2018, 110) master-slave dialectic, which requires “self-conscious individuals...mutually recognizing each other”. The master demands recognition from the slave dominating him, in doing so, the slave becomes a “fully developed self-consciousness...the true hero of this story, rather than the conquering...master” (24). Their relationship could partially epitomize this Hegelian struggle for mutual recognition and authority. Initially, Schultz echoes “the master” freeing Django and imposing a hierarchical relationship for which he accomplishes Schultz’s intentions. Oppositely, Django becomes “the slave”; subordinated and recognised for his initial utility, and hence, deprived of his total freedom. Nonetheless, their dependence emphasizes “the nature of humanity...[that] drive men to agreement with one another” (43); this agreement involves a business and the implicit defiance of the system.

As the film advances, the Hegelian dialectic results in Schultz's dependence on Django's company and worth; Schultz has "the authority to bestow...recognition." (24), cherishing Django, who becomes recognized for his success. Schultz considers a more egalitarian relationship by empowering him, appreciating Django's potential, and helping him to chase his dream. In challenging the system, Django is self-conscious of his power and asserts his agency even emancipating from Schultz's dependence; he "had to die,... to liberate and empower Django." (Vogel 2018, 26). Irrefutably, Schultz's decease (Tarantino 2012, 02:10:45-02:11:36) marks a turning point for detaching dependently. Django has to combat alone the system's perils and be responsible and resilient to becoming a hero.

These perpetuating discourse traces are crucial in understanding how Django applies the dynamics he learns from Schultz and Whites' interactions to create a persona that subverts the discourse. He judiciously manipulates Kipling's (1954) narrative; their allegiance constitutes a chance of "unchaining", and retaliating in a racially divided society. He does the same with the master-slave dialectic, accepting to obey Schultz does not require any effort since his background. Conversely, he receives the proposal as an opportunity to liberate and learn how to shoot, interpret roles according to the situation, and handle in society, which would subsequently help him to pursue justice and surmount a White supremacist regime that repudiates Blacks.

2. 4 An Atypical Team

Together they form a distorting law apparatus acting for justice and bounties. Insofar as Django is analysed Schultz must not be forgotten, since he is the key to Django's apprenticeship, rebellion and freedom. The violence Django instils can be compared to the cruel treatment Blacks receive from White characters, who consider them inferior. Trouillot (1995, 20) alleges: "The production of historical narratives involves the uneven contribution of...individuals who have unequal access to the means for such". Django overthrew these narratives' disparity reuniting all this violence and hate and turning them into a weapon against Whites by using a complex strategy based on role-play, a Schultz's taught mechanism. Thus, when exacting justice, they play a different character, which grants Django's rebellion. He offers resistance "the most spontaneous development of his individuality" (Foucault 1977, 292) to the oppressive system's hardships, which allows distorting the discourse through mimicry while encouraging the Black American Dream by applying all he learnt.

3. The Power of Mimicry: A Double-Edged Sword with a Subversive Goal

3.1 Django's Subversion through Mimicry

According to Bhabha (1984, 129), *mimicry* emerges as an “erratic, eccentric strategy of authority in colonial discourse”. The scholar asserts that the hegemonic authority has the “desire for a reformed...Other, as a subject of a difference that is almost the same, but not quite” (122). Mimicry relies on copying, thus, requiring the Other to appropriate the dominating discourse and acting as an emulator. Bhabha (122) writes: “Mimicry is constructed around an ambivalence; to be effective, mimicry must continually produce its slippage, its excess, its difference”, hence, perpetuating inequalities and limitations through hyperbole. Nonetheless, it could be used as a subversive tactic; Django applies it when he becomes a bounty hunter, a White strategy, as a medium to pursue his aspiration.

In this replication procedure, “The desire to emerge as ‘authentic’ through mimicry is the final irony of partial representation” (126). In the end, the Other “mimes the forms of authority at the point at which it deauthorizes them” (126). In other words, while mimicry strengthens White elites’ power, replicating the authority only produces ambivalent imitators whose mimicry induces mockery. Undoubtedly, mimicry is used throughout the film as a mechanism to reevaluate and defy (post)colonial presumptions by adopting and reiterating those prejudiced practices. By mimicking, Django became better than the expected copy, as cruel and violent as Whites exploiting Blacks.

This Black cowboy subverts the conventional role and uses White violent strategies to combat slavery and racism. Django embodies the hero saving his wife and fostering Black freedom by replicating White’s behaviour, appearance, and speech as an incendiary mechanism to mock them. He plays different roles considering Schultz’s advice of never breaking the character in his prescription to improve Django’s situation. Thanks to these instructions he manages mimicry as a subversive tool ridiculing Whites.

3.1.1 Ambivalence

The way Django imitates Whites is disrespectfully perceived by those who, in their desire to reform the “Other” do not expect the copy to become a mirror of the original. This exposes the mimicry discourse turning against them, portraying the ambivalence of rejecting an identical clone. This is perceivable in:

- 1) Citizens **in Daughtrey** detect a daring in Django riding a horse (Tarantino 2012, 00:13:20-00:14:15)
- 2) **The Saloon Keeper:** “What the hell you think you doin' boy, get that nigger outta here”. (00:14:23)
- 3) **Bennet:** “It's against the law for niggers to ride horses in this territory”. (00:28:20)

3.1.2 Vocabulary

Furthermore, Django's dynamics of impersonating Whites' vocabulary represent an act of mockery. As perceived in:

Crash: Oh, now you are a lucky nigger.

Django: You better listen to your boss white boy.

(01:14:48 - 01:14:52)

Here, he reverted the defamatory *nigger* “white people [used] and consider[ed] as an inappropriate word” (Rachmadi 2017, 26) to “white boy” overturning the prejudiced “way of speaking to colored people” (Douglass 2003, 132). With this roguery he asserts he is different, imposing his agency while subverting the discourse.

3.1.3 Appearance

On a different note, Django also imitates White's clothing style (Rachmadi, 2017). He starts by wearing tattered pants and a careless hairstyle to replicate White's outfit when becoming a bounty hunter. This transition is shown when playing a valet at Bennett's plantation. There, he decides to wear outlandish clothes:

Schultz: You may choose your character's costume

Django: Is going to let me pick up my own clothes?

(Tarantino 2012, 00:27:48 - 00:27:56)

As the film advances (ca. 00:65:00) he wears a cowboy outfit; a hat, a belt, a holster and a revolver. Thus, “Django leaves his old habits in the way he dresses and...he talks” (Rachmadi 2017, 24).

Fannon (1968) explains that the violence exerted on oppressed individuals unites them against the chaining system. Contrastingly, the fact that Django is free and behaves as Whites is perceived as incomprehensible by many slaves:

Betina: So you really free?

Django: Yes

Betina: You mean you wanna dress like that?

(00:32:07-00:32:12)

At Bennett's, Betina, a slave maiden, judges him for being eccentrically dressed, denoting mockery and patheticness.

On the other hand, this incomprehensibility is perceived as anger when he has to play a "One-Eyed Charly": "nothin lower than a black slaver" (8FLiX 2012, 71). He mimics how Whites treat slaves, and much as he does not enjoy it, he needs to be convincing in a closer step toward his dream.

3.2 Stephen as an Antithesis.

In contraposition, Stephen represents the other side of the coin, using mimicry as a discourse perpetrator fomenting racial oppression. Stephen "has inferior feelings, he admires the colonizer that much that he wants to be one of [them]" (Rachmadi 2017, 31), hence, he acts as a system's supervisor. He "induce[s]...a state of...permanent visibility that assures the automatic functioning of power" (Foucault 1977, 201), thus, he participates in the collective subjugation by dispraising Blacks and becoming an ISA. He hates Django's freedom and the way he subverts the discourse, demonstrating repulsion for his apparition in Candyland and being reluctant to his stay in the Big House (Tarantino 2012, 01:28:45-01:30:24). He calls Django "nigger" mimicking the way Whites talk to them, strengthening the discourse as a panopticon overseer. He appears restless for Django's pursuit of buying a Mandingo, and such is his perception that he discovers the team plan.

When Schultz kills Candie, Stephen desires Django to suffer the most painful fate considering the already exhibited brutal practices non-special, hence, showcasing: "peoples in revolt...answer[ed] by force" (Fanon 1968, 24). He rejoices in Django's destiny deprived of humanity when sold to Dickey. Nonetheless, with his wit and bounty hunter's mastery, Django cheated Dickey by mimicrying Schultz's speech (Tarantino 2012, 02:23:25-02:25:20). After all, Django is freed, frees some slaves, revenges on Candie's supporters including Stephen, and liberates Broomhilda. Even at his end Stephen "belie[ves] that slavery...can't be overthrown" (Baud 2003, 11) as perceived in his final monologue: "This is Candyland, nigger! You can't destroy Candyland!" (Tarantino 2012, 02:39:50-02:39:56). However, Django's detonating the house metaphorically implies "the destruction of the institution" (Baud 2003, 11).

3.3 Comparing Both Cases

Everything considered, "Django and Steven clearly mimic the White people, but they have different reasons to mimic [them]" (Rachmadi 2017, 6), showcasing that mimicry can be used

as a surveillant tool reinforcing the discourse, or as a subversive key enhancing resilience and empowerment, as Django does. The ambivalence of the colonial discourse varies between mimicry and mockery (Bhabha, 1984). Hence, Django's mimicry results in an exaggerated imitation of Whites culminating in their ridicule. In contraposition, Stephen's dominant discourse mimesis leads to mockery by failing to empathise with the oppressed, albeit being part of them. On balance, Django subverts White assumed superiority, challenging their practices as a quest for justice and conscience combating racism, a crucial step for the Black American Dream.

4. Django, the Spur of the Black American Dream in Fiction

Django achieves his goal by freeing his wife from bondage while revenging on racial perpetrators in Candyland. This film's slogan is: "Life, Liberty, and Pursuit of Vengeance" (Tarantino, 2012); Schultz grants Django's life as "unchained", however, Django gains his total freedom after Schultz's death, and using subversion as a resilient and resistant tool in front of power apparatuses he manages his revenge. Undoubtedly, Django encapsulates the "attempt to offer a revised history from the perspective of the non-white...shifting dispositions of power" (Vogel 2018, 19). Furthermore, while fighting for his ambition, Django catalyzes a Black revolution by stating a model of Black freedom and calling for "justice, equality, and peace before ideologies of racism" (Davis 2012, 147), thus, the American Dream pinnacle (Zangrandos, 1970) without Blacks' restrictions.

Armstrong et al. (2019, 227) state that the American dream (TAD) "is an ideological symbol of achievement and success in American culture". Aquila (2015, 337) adds that "hardworking individuals, regardless of their background or heritage, could strike it rich if they had the skills and determination to succeed". Notwithstanding, "historical barriers to equal opportunities and economic attainment through racial discrimination have limited access to TAD" (Armstrong et al. 2019, 227). One of these barriers was slavery, but racism is another obstacle that persists in today's society; as Baldwin (1963, 120) claimed "the American dream has...become something much more closely resembling a nightmare". The promise of equality in all ambits regardless of the context is a great slogan that does not match reality, a consequence of "race" as a construction based on power assumptions (Delgado and Stefancic, 2012).

Django seeks justice for Whites' exerted brutality, urging Blacks' fairer treatment and helping them to protect their "dream[s] [to be] deferred" (Hughes, 1990, 313) due to injustices.

He suffers hardships but never surrenders. Thus, he stands as a reference for facing injustices and overturning conventions. Django's feats especially when freeing some slaves may represent an uncovering of, as Hughes presents, the reality that African Americans suffered in lacking access to TAD, which can be extended to "condemning present-day injustices" (Nelson 2010, 294). They feel sentenced to "dry up" (Hughes 1990, 313) any dream each has—a dream for equity or improvement encompassing, thus, TAD's attainment—due to racial discrimination. Django visibilizes this toll using subversion as a response to their oppression persistent even after slavery, embodying a fighter who demands consideration for their dreams.

Django's release coincided with Obama's election, what Davis (2012, 147) understands as "the America that can potentially provide the leadership we need during these difficult times". In doing so, I argue that Tarantino, despite being a White who cannot fully grasp racism's toll (Angott, 2016), gives visibility and justice to Blacks. This aligns with Angott's (16) manifestation of the "role that whites...need to play in the evolution and reconciliation of America's conscience" and Baldwin's (1963, 141) urgency that Whites and Blacks aware of the situation disseminate consciousness to "end the racial nightmare".

Tarantino's intention "was to give Black American males a western hero...a cool folkloric hero that could...be empowering, and actually pay back blood for blood" (Interviewee Guru-Murthy, in Vogel 2018, 17). This contemplation resembles Fanonian's (1968, 35) ideology that overturning "colonization [, whose vestiges are still confronted,] is always a violent phenomenon". Shifting this conception, I contend that Tarantino empowers Blacks by presenting a Black hero who subverts the discourse with mimicry. This demonstrates that the historically labelled "inferior" are not, criticizing the assumed White superiority, nothing more than a convenient narrative.

The film represents a catharsis, underscoring Django's victory over despotism, and calls for rethinking current racism as a legacy of past discourses. I argue that the broadcast appeals to an antiracist society since it is not completely about "right[ing] the wrongs of the past" (Vogel 2018, 17), but rather considering Django's transformation in asserting his agency and freedom. This matches Zangrandos' (1970, 153) ideas that while Whites focus on a materialistic outlook of the dream, Blacks "emphasize community through the instruments of black awareness and black identity". This is visible in Django raising consciousness of Blacks' power and demanding a wake-up call for Whites to stop perpetuating racism, since "the glorification of one race and the consequent debasement of another...always has been and always will be a recipe for murder" (Baldwin 1963, 112). Django's revenge against slavery and racism may be

interpreted as a universal retribution for the wrongs historically done, presenting a lesson applicable to nowadays; skin colour should not determine anything.

Django Unchained (2012) conveys the idea that a “heat of injustice and oppression, will be transformed into an oasis of freedom and justice” (King, 1963). This film encompasses Baldwin’s (1963) convictions on demanding actions to change reality, since as Davis (2012, 64) argues “resistance to racism can only be effective if it is anchored in global communities of struggle”, urging a rethinking in all watched countries. Hence, only when Blacks are allowed to fully access TAD regardless of race (Zangrandos, 1970) will society advance. The production seemingly aims “to remove the hateful, jarring, and incongruous elements...to unite all...to remedy that wrong” (King, 1963). It emerged in a time of required “support for equality at the same time [of] police repression and great inequality” (Angott 2016, 16).

All in all, *Django* represents subversion and resistance to power racial apparatus fighting against the global concern of inequality, injustice and repression. He sets an example of the Black American dream “bring[ing] awareness..., the first step toward overcoming...another barrier in the struggle for racial equality.” (Bell 1980, 533). *Django Unchained* (2012) fosters a quest for Black freedom, emphasizing justice, liberty from racial assumptions, and commitment to denouncing the perpetuation of racism, since “the black and the white, deeply need each other...if [they] are really to become a nation” (Baldwin 1963, 131).

Conclusion

Django Unchained (2012) presents historical U.S. insights, exploring the hegemonic discourse that dictated Blacks’ treatment through slavery, segregation and stereotypes. Thus, it reflects how power operates and introduces the antecedent of current racism. Notwithstanding, it provides an alternative and exaggerated outlook by disrupting ISAs’ practices by facing slavery’s oppression and exploring Black freedom. This context is crucial for comprehending this revisionist Western’s weight in rethinking and unchaining from this genre's dominant guidelines. It defies the established racial power schemes by subverting Western conventions, namely, selecting a Black cowboy protagonist.

When examining *Django*, Schultz’s role is imperative in unchaining him, both physically and rebelliously. Schultz is a complex character who may be read as an abolitionist, encouraging *Django* in a skewed racial society and interceding for slaves against the White forces, or a perpetrator of the system, egotistically guided by his interests. He is initially presented as a White saviour, enforcing “The White Man’s Burden” (Kipling, 1954) ideology

and setting a master-slave dialectic example. Ultimately, Django took advantage of these narratives by learning how to mimic Whites as a subverting tool, further demonstrating the ambivalent colonial discourse's remnant while fostering the Black American Dream. He simulates dominant behaviours, mien and speech turning them into a distorted imitation that distils mockery, which serves to denounce the absurdity and insensitivity of slavery and racism. Contrarily, Stephen is considered a counterpoint strengthening the discourse by mirroring it; he acts as a panoptic character of the dominant ideology which ends in mockery for his antipathy.

Shifting gears, Django chases the dream of liberating Broomhilda from bondage while also giving a chance to other slaves in 1858, thus, defying the oppressive system. Despite his hardships, he is resilient, calling the Blacks never to surrender in pursuing freedom and equality. In Django's asserting his agency lies the foundation of an antiracist quest, calling Whites to cease discrimination by mocking their actions and demanding Blacks equal access to TAD. On balance, power ideology's revision allows the audience to comprehend how mimicry is used as a subverting tool fostering the Black American dream. This is emphasised through the format, a revisionist Western which "unchains", hence, empowers a historically silenced community. Tarantino challenges the hegemonic perspective by changing the systematic role of the White cowboy to a Black, thus, reconsidering and disrupting the established tradition. This historical inaccuracy allows Django to become a representative of the Black community, combating slavery and discrimination, ultimately detonating the representative Candyland, thus, dismantling inequalities.

Finally, and due to word limitations future analysis might consider to what extent inequality is currently considered a burden and if this case of subversion fostering empowerment has been a source for creating a new society in which African American inhabitants are equal to anyone. This could be examined by interpreting ongoing violence statistics directed at Blacks, a reminiscence of the struggles historically suffered, while discussing the role campaigns such as the BLM have in fixing this problem.

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